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Art 42
Mr. Kilcrease
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Art Evaluation

The key aspect analyzed in this essay will be about an artwork being evaluated. This artwork is by Kerry James Marshall. Titled "*Better Homes Better Gardens*" (1994). I will be using a multitude of types of art forms to describe & critique. The types of art forms I will be using are Elements of Art, Principles of Design, Contextual & Expressive.

The main thing in the artwork is a couple. This couple is walking hand in hand towards a part that isn't depicted inside the painting. Towards the left of the couple, there is a sign. The sign says "Welcome to Wentworth Gardens." Infront of the sign, there are overgrown flowers displayed, seeming to be dried up. In the background, there are apartment buildings with trees & flowers & clouds shaped forms. The sky contains sunrays, clouds & birds.

In the artwork shown, the focal point is the people or the sign in the left corner. The people are hand in hand. The artwork contains multiple elements but it seems like it lacks unity. Warm colors are at play as there are different shades of yellows, oranges, & reds throughout the artwork, as well as a hint of a couple of other colors. There are also organic shapes present, like in the spewing water on the right side of the sign.

I see a multitude of different lines, some I spot on the first look are spiral, thin, varied, & wavy. Composition is also displayed in the artwork, note how the flowers are arranged infront of the sign to show composition. I also believe that leading lines are present, the road lines below the couple are leading right towards them. They're there so the audience's attention could be on

the couple displayed. High Contrast is present as well as shading, the colors in the artwork are extremely saturated, and there seem to be no dim or light colors, most being bright.

The shading is a point that also fits in with emphasis, throughout the whole artwork, nothing is shaded, and most of the elements like the walls of the buildings, the sign & floor aren't shaded but the couple in the artwork are. This emphasizes the couple, they stand out. Their outfits are heavily shaded, looking almost realistic. In the art book, it says, “**Formal theories**, which focus attention on the composition of the work and how it shows originality, how it may have been influenced by other works, or how it influences other artists” (Prebles’ Artform, pg 88).

Surrounded by this couple, are a multitude of apartment buildings. They appear to be semi-new, telling by the sign, but it's covered up by the large flowers. The couple isn't speaking to one another, the woman looking at the man, whilst the male stares at the audience. This artwork's meaning could be about a community. More telling by the friendliness of the couple. They don't give off a bad feeling, but more of a warm, welcoming one. For example, in an article depicting this artwork, “Better Homes, Better Gardens is part of a series of paintings that Marshall calls the “Garden Project.” The paintings in this series portray scenes that suggest the complexity of life in low-income housing projects.” (*Better Homes, Better Gardens* | *Denver Art Museum*, 1 Jan. 1994).

One thing about this painting is that it brings ease to the eyes. With color overly bright but still brought down in saturation. It gives off this feeling of comfort. The way this painting is set up reminds me of a younger life living in middle-class areas. The area is brought to life with small details, like the hose or the ball on the ground. I believe this is what Kerry James Marshall was going for. This can be seen in a text, “Many of Marshall's paintings refer to the 1960s, the

period of his youth and the rise of the civil rights movement.” (Yood, James W. “Kerry James Marshall.” *Encyclopædia Britannica*, Encyclopædia Britannica, inc.). This can bring in how Marshall depicts himself through his works of art.

To summarize, Kerry James Marshalls' “Better Homes Better Gardens” painting, is filled with great meaning, along with his other works. You can truly tell he puts time and effort into his art, putting emotion & emphasis on certain parts to make stand out. He includes multiple elements of art & Principles of Design in his works. To show his paintings explode with color to many small details being noted down.

Works Cited:

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